

Beyond The Mudras
An Arangetram Magazine

Mudhraas

Mudras are symbolic hand gestures used in Bharatanatyam to communicate emotions, objects, actions and stories.
The word Mudra originates from Sanskrit and refers to a symbolic gesture or seal. Their use in Indian performing arts is documented in ancient texts such as the Natya Shastra and Abhinaya Darpana.

In Bharatanatyam, hand gestures are called Hasta Mudras or Hastas. They are used to communicate emotions, objects, actions, nature, and stories through hand movements.

There are 28 Asamyuta Hastas (single-hand gestures) and 24 Samyuta Hastas (double-hand gestures) according to the Abhinaya Darpana tradition :

Asamyuta hastas :

1.Pataka – Flag, clouds, forest, blessing.



2. Tripataka **–** Crown, tree, fire.



3. Ardhapataka – Leaves, riverbank, knife.



4. Kartarimukha – Separation, lightning, corners.



5. Mayura – Peacock, feathers, applying tilak.



6. Ardhachandra – Half moon, hand of the waist.



7. Arala – Drinking nectar.



8. Shukatunda – Parrot's head, shooting an arrow.



9. Mushti – Fist, strength.



10. Shikhara – Bow, pillar, holding objects.



11. Kapittha – Holding cymbals Lakshmi, Saraswati.



12. Katakamukha – Holding a flower, necklace.



13. Suchi – One, pointing, showing something



14. Chandrakala – Moon.



15. Padmakosha – Lotus bud, fruit.



16. Sarpashirsha – Snake's head.



17. Mrigashirsha – Deer, face.



18. Simhamukha – Lion's face.



19. Kangula – Bell, small fruit.



20. Alapadma – Fully bloomed lotus.



21. Chatura – Little, gold, sorrow.



22. Bhramara – Bee.



23. Hamsasya – Swan's beak, delicate objects.



24. Hamsapaksha – Swan's wing



25. Sandamsha – Offering, biting.



26. Mukula – Flower bud, eating.



27. Tamrachuda – Rooster.



28. Trishula – Trident, three.



Samyuta Hastas

1. Anjali – Greeting, prayer.



2. Kapota – Respect, humility.



3. Karkata – Crab, gathering.



4. Swastika – Crossed hands.



5. Dola – Hanging hands.



6. Pushpaputa – Offering flowers.



7. Utsanga – Embrace.



8. Shivalinga – Lord Shiva.



9. Katakavardhana – Coronation.



10. Kartariswastika – Branches, trees



11. Shakata – Demon.



12. Shankha – Conch shell.



13. Chakra – Wheel



14. Samputa – Box, covering something.



15. Pasha – Rope, bond.



16. Kilaka – Love, affection.



17. Matsya – Fish.



18. Kurma – Tortoise.



19. Varaha – Boar.



20. Garuda – Garuda, divine bird.



21. Nagabandha – Serpents.



22. Khatva – Bedstead.



23. Bherunda – Two-headed bird.



24. Avahitta – Concealing, modesty.



Marangam

The Margam is the traditional sequence of dance items performed during a Bharatanatyam recital. The word Margam means "path" or "journey" in Sanskrit. Each item has a different purpose, gradually taking the audience from rhythmic movements to expressive storytelling and finally to a conclusion.
The traditional Margam was systematised by the Tanjore Quartet (Chinnayya, Ponnayya, Sivanandam and Vadivelu) during the 19th century. However, the exact programme of an Arangetram is not fixed. It can change depending on the dancer's training, the guru's preferences, the choreography, the available time, and the artistic theme of the performance.

1.Alaripu

Alarippu is traditionally the opening item of a Bharatanatyam performance. The word is associated with blossoming, symbolising the gradual awakening of the dancer's body and mind. It is primarily a rhythmic dance involving coordinated movements of the head, neck, shoulders, hands and feet. It generally does not involve elaborate storytelling or facial expressions. Instead, it introduces the audience to the rhythm and technique of Bharatanatyam.

2. Jatiswaram

Jatiswaram is a pure dance item that focuses on rhythm, musical notes, and movement. It combines Jatis (rhythmic patterns) with Swaras (musical notes). Unlike expressive storytelling pieces, Jatiswaram mainly showcases the dancer's technical ability, including precise footwork, body coordination, balance, and geometric movements. It demonstrates how dance movements can be organised around the structure of Carnatic music.

3. Shabdam

Shabdam introduces storytelling and expression into the Margam. The word means "sound" or "word". It combines rhythmic movements with Abhinaya, allowing dancers to communicate the lyrics' meaning through facial expressions, gestures, and body language. Shabdams often contain devotional themes and may describe or praise Hindu deities such as Krishna, Shiva, or Vishnu

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4. Varnam

Varnam is traditionally the central and most elaborate item of a Bharatanatyam recital. It combines Nritta (pure dance) and Abhinaya (expressive storytelling). It requires considerable stamina, technical skill, and emotional expression. Through intricate rhythmic sequences and expressive passages, dancers communicate complex stories and emotions. Varnams often explore themes of devotion, longing and love, sometimes portraying a devotee's relationship with a deity.

5. Padam

Padam is an expressive dance item that focuses primarily on emotions, facial expressions, and storytelling rather than complicated rhythmic movements. The dancer interprets poetic lyrics, often exploring themes such as devotion, love, separation, longing, jealousy, and relationships. Padams allow the dancer to demonstrate their understanding of Abhinaya by portraying different characters, emotions, and situations. They are often performed at a slower pace, giving the audience time to understand the story and its emotional depth.

6. Javali

Javali is a lighter form of expressive dance that often explores romantic themes and human relationships. Unlike devotional Padams, Javalis frequently portray everyday romantic situations, such as attraction, affection, playful teasing, and misunderstandings. They are generally performed at a livelier pace and allow the dancer to demonstrate subtle expressions, characterisation and storytelling. Javalis are not compulsory in every Arangetram and may be included depending on the dancer's repertoire and the guru's choice.

7. Tillana

Tillana is a lively, energetic dance item traditionally performed toward the end of a Bharatanatyam recital. It focuses on intricate rhythmic patterns, fast footwork, coordinated movements, and graceful poses. Its music features rhythmic syllables called Jatis and melodic passages. Although Tillana primarily showcases pure dance, it may also contain a short devotional section towards the end. It allows the dancer to demonstrate their technical precision, stamina, and stage presence.

8. Mangalam

Mangalam is traditionally the concluding item of a Bharatanatyam performance. The word means auspiciousness or well-being. It is usually a short devotional piece in which the dancer expresses gratitude and offers prayers to the divine, their guru, musicians and audience. It marks the completion of the performance and brings the recital to a respectful and meaningful close.

The Four Types of Abhinaya

Abhinaya is the art of expression in Bharatanatyam. It allows dancers to communicate stories, emotions and meanings through different forms of expression. There are four main types:

1. Angika Abhinaya: Expressing meaning through body movements, including hand gestures (mudras), facial expressions, eye movements and posture.

2. Vachika Abhinaya: Expressing meaning through speech, words, songs and music. In Bharatanatyam, the dancer usually conveys the meaning of the song through movement and expression.

3. Aharya Abhinaya: Using costumes, jewellery, makeup and other visual elements to represent characters and enhance the performance.

4. Sattvika Abhinaya: Expressing genuine emotions, such as happiness, sadness, anger and love, through subtle facial expressions and emotional intensity.

Music and Instruments in Bharatanatyam

Music is an essential part of Bharatanatyam, as it guides the dancer's movements, rhythm and expressions. Performances traditionally use Carnatic music, the classical music tradition of South India. The main instruments and musical roles include:

1. Nattuvangam: Small cymbals played by the dance teacher or conductor to keep rhythm and guide the dancer through rhythmic patterns.

2. Mridangam: A double-sided drum that provides the main rhythmic accompaniment.

3. Violin: Adds melody and supports the vocalist and dancer.

4. Flute: Produces melodic tunes that add depth and emotion to the performance.

5. Veena: A traditional string instrument that creates melodic accompaniment.

6. Vocalist: Sings the lyrics of the compositions, helping communicate the story and emotions behind the dance.

Together, these instruments and vocals create the rhythm and melody that bring a Bharatanatyam performance to life.

A Beginner's Guide to Watching Bharatanatyam

Watching a Bharatanatyam performance becomes more meaningful when you understand what to look and listen for. Even without prior knowledge of the dance form, you can appreciate the following:

1. Hand Gestures (Mudras): Notice how dancers use hand gestures to represent objects, characters, actions and ideas.

2. Facial Expressions (Abhinaya): Observe how the dancer uses their eyes, eyebrows and facial expressions to communicate emotions and tell stories.

3. Footwork and Rhythm: Listen to the music and watch how the dancer's foot movements match the beats and rhythmic patterns.

4. Body Movements: Notice the dancer's posture, balance, movements and coordination.

5. Costumes and Jewellery: Look at the traditional costume, jewellery and makeup, which contribute to the visual beauty of the performance.

6. Storytelling: Try to understand the story or emotion being presented, especially during expressive items such as the Varnam and Padam.

Bharatanatyam is much more than a dance form; it is a beautiful expression of Indian culture, history and tradition. Through its movements, mudras, expressions, music and storytelling, it allows dancers to communicate emotions and preserve stories passed down through generations. An Arangetram marks an important milestone in a dancer's journey, celebrating years of dedication, practice and learning. By understanding the different elements of this performance, audiences can develop a deeper appreciation for Bharatanatyam and the cultural heritage it represents.

Thank you